times. From about 300 BCE onwards it gave the Chera rulers of Karur – known to the Greek scholar Ptolemy as Korevora, a once-flourishing town on a side tributary of the Cauvery (Kaveri) River – access to the sea-coast, leading to their initial control of the profitable sea-trade with Arabia and the Mediterranean world. Many centuries later it gave the Tamil Brahmins access to Malabar. Later still it served as a gateway for the Perso-Afghan general Hyder Ali and his son Tipu Sultan in their numerous assaults on Malabar.

The Western Ghats rise to no more than 8760 feet (2670 metres) at their highest point, but that is enough to catch the full force of the South-West Monsoon. This has kept the western shoreline thoroughly well-watered, creating lush tropical rain-forests wonderfully rich in their biodiversity. On the Roman *Tabula Peutingeriana* map in Vienna (of which more in Chapter 3) the Western Ghats are shown as 'Mons Lymodus', with an accompanying inscription which reads *In hic locis elephanti nasciunter*: 'In this place elephants are born'. Today those same forests constitute the last viable sanctuaries for the wild elephant in India, even though these sanctuaries are now divided by forest encroachment into eight separated populations. The Indian wild elephant has had a hard time of it in South India, in the past because of its use as a weapon of war – the ancient equivalent of the panzer tank – but in more recent centuries because of its servitude as a so-called temple elephant. Today Elephant Family, set up by the late Mark Shand, is just one of a number of charities working in partnership with the Wildlife Trust of India and local forest departments to create corridors between the fragmented sanctuaries in Kerala and Karnataka.

The Western Ghats have also created a rain-shadow, leaving the central plateau starved of rainfall. That means its rich volcanic soil can offer only limited forest cover in the form of sub-tropical dry forest and scrubland, providing poor grazing and poorer harvests. What saves this interior from